

▼ SUPER SCAVENGERS

Despite the chill, these scavenging starfish thrive on the seabed beneath the floating ice of the Antarctic Weddell Sea.



ICE FISH

Salty seawater doesn't freeze until its temperature falls to almost 28.4°F (−2°C)—lower than the freezing point of most animals' bodies. Specialized animals such as this Antarctic ice fish survive because natural antifreezes in their bodies usually stop them from getting lethal frostbite.

▲ GHOSTLIKE

An ice fish has a ghostly appearance because its blood is colorless—it does not contain the red cells that absorb oxygen. In the oxygen-rich polar water, its blood can carry enough oxygen without them.

SEABED DANGERS

The wealth of food in cold polar seas means that those seabed animals able to survive the near-freezing water beneath the ice can flourish in huge numbers. But these animals live under constant threat of being ground to a pulp by ice floes drifting into the shallows, or being frozen solid by ice forming around them in the water.



▲ WEDDELL SEALS

These seals hunt further south than any other seals, staying close to the Antarctic coast when the sea freezes over in winter.

HARD TIMES

Many seals hunt under the floating ice, surfacing to breathe at the ice edge or in small patches of open water. Around Antarctica, Weddell seals hunt fish and squid beneath the thick ice near the shore. They use their teeth to chip away the ice to make breathing holes. This gradually wears their teeth down, and can even give them serious toothaches.

